

5.1 The Slide Master, Introduced

A slide consists of three *layers*: the object layer, the slide master layer, and the background layer. Imagine them stacked one on top of the other. The object layer lies on top, followed by the slide master layer, with the background layer at the bottom. When you work with PowerPoint, you normally work on the object layer. This is where you add or edit text boxes, images, AutoShapes, WordArt, and such.

The slide master layer lies directly beneath the object layer and controls. The slide master—and remember these—consists of:

- The default layout of the placeholders (the dotted boxes that contain text, graphics and other objects);
- The default background and colour scheme;
- The default type and size of fonts and bullets used within the text boxes of the object layer; and
- Any text, logos, graphics, images and objects that should appear on all slides.

As a result, then, the slide master allows you to create a uniform look and feel for all the slides in your presentation. Thus, for example, if you want to include your company logo on all slides, you would use the slide master to add the logo. It will subsequently appear on all new slides created ([Ctrl] + [M]) then on.

Underneath the slide master is the background. The background is the “canvas” on which your presentation is displayed. It can be a solid or gradient colour, graphics, or a picture object. For more details on backgrounds, see chapter 12.

You use a design template to standardise presentations, in conjunction with the design elements you want to repeat across all your presentations. For example, you may want to standardise one presentation format for the sales team, another for training, and yet another format for induction of new recruits. Each of these are customisable as design templates. Your colleagues can use these templates—they can just go ahead and fill in the content without needing to worry about the design aspect of it.